

Julianna J. Thomson

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Education

George Mason University	Expected May 2027
Ph.D. Candidate, Political Science	
Comprehensive Exams: American Government, International Relations	
Committee: Mark J. Rozell (Chair), Robert J. McGrath, Kendrick Kuo, James P. Pfiffner	
Dissertation: Sacred Speech in a Secularizing Society: Congress, the President, and the Politics of Religious Rhetoric	
Villanova University	2022
M.B.A.	
Specialization: Strategic Management	
Dartmouth College	2020
A.B., Religion	
Exchange Program: New College School of Theology, University of Edinburgh	

Additional Training

The Institute for Qualitative and Multi-Method Research (IQMR), Syracuse University	2025
Graduate Teaching Academy, Stearns Center for Teaching and Learning, George Mason University	2025

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

2. **Thomson, Julianna J.**, and Mark J. Rozell. 2025. "Challenges to Protecting Religious Freedoms: The Roles of Government and Societal Norms." *Ethos. Quarterly of the John Paul II Catholic University of Lublin*. 38(3):155-73. <https://doi.org/10.12887/38-2025-3-151-10>.
1. **Thomson, Julianna J.**, and Alena Smith. 2025. "Sacred Speech: Analyzing the Influence of Congressional Leadership on Religious Rhetoric." *Politics and Religion*. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S1755048325100102>.
 - Awarded the Society for the Scientific Study of Religion 2025 Student Paper Award for the best student paper published in 2025.

Book Chapters

1. Carty, Thomas J., and **Julianna J. Thomson**. 2025. "Catholic Senators and Abortion Politics: The Cases of Joe Biden and Ted Kennedy." In *Religion and Congress: The Intersection of Faith and Politics*, edited by David A. Dulio and Colton C. Campbell, 97–114. Boulder, Colorado: Lynne Rienner Publishers, Inc.
 - Book reviewed here: <https://doi.org/10.1017/S1537592726104551>

Public Scholarship

2. Smith, Alena, and **Julianna J. Thomson**. 2025. "The 2026 Midterms: Speaker Mike Johnson's Religious Rhetoric Will Continue to Shape How Republicans Speak to Their Constituents." London School of Economics United States Centre (blog). <https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/usappblog/2025/07/30/the-2026-midterms-speaker-mike-johnsons-religious-rhetoric-will-continue-to-shape-how-republicans-speak-to-their-constituents/>.
1. Smith, Alena, and **Julianna J. Thomson**. 2025. "The Johnson Effect: How the New Speaker Sparked a Religious Rhetoric Surge." Religion in Public (blog). <https://religioninpublic.blog/2025/07/14/the-johnson-effect-how-the-new-speaker-sparked-a-religious-rhetoric-surge/>.

Research in Progress

Under Review:

“Gendered Differences in Leadership and Political Ambition Among NCAA Student-Athletes” with Cammie Jo Bolin (University at Albany)

“How Proximity to National Parks Shapes Voting Behavior: Evidence from U.S. Counties, 2000-2024” with Stephen Gailliot (George Mason University)

In Progress:

“Christian Nationalism in Congressional Communication in the Twenty-First Century” with Cammie Jo Bolin (University at Albany) and Alena Smith (Stanford University) - *Abstract accepted for the Political Studies Review special issue, “250th Anniversary of the United States of America’s Founding: America at a Turning Point?”.*

The Christian Right: What Everyone Needs to Know with Mark J. Rozell (George Mason University) and Clyde Wilcox (Georgetown University) - *Under contract with Oxford University Press.*

“IRS Policy Change and Political Endorsements from the Pulpit: Evidence from U.S. Sermons” with Alena Smith (Stanford University)

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record

“Religion and the American Presidency,” Encore Learning

Fall 2024

Research and Work Experience

Graduate Research Assistant, Schar School of Policy and Government 2022-2026

Research Assistant to Dr. Mark J. Rozell, Dean of the Schar School of Policy and Government

Business Research Fellow, Villanova School of Business 2020-2022

Research Assistant to Dr. Jonathan Doh, Senior Associate Dean for Research

Research Assistant to Dr. Denise Downey, KPMG Endowed Professor in Accounting

Senior Admissions Fellow, Dartmouth College 2019-2020

Research Intern, Council for Advancement and Support of Education 2018

Awards, Fellowships, and Grants

George Mason University

Presidential Scholarship (full tuition and stipend) 2022–2026

Daniel Druckman Fellowship (\$8000) 2025

Schar School IQMR Grant (\$3025) 2025

May La Due Bishop Book Fund (\$1200) 2024

Schar School Conference Travel Grant (total \$5000) 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026

Villanova University

Graduate Research Fellowship (full tuition and stipend) 2020–2022

Dartmouth College

Religion Department Faculty Prize (\$750) 2020

Citation for Meritorious Performance 2019

External

APSA Graduate Student Support Grant (\$150)	2025
Society for the Scientific Study of Religion Student Paper Award (\$500)	2025
ASREC Graduate Student Workshop Grant (\$800)	2023
All-Academic First Team, Big East Conference	2021, 2022

Conference Presentations

10. "Congress, the President, and the Politics of Religious Rhetoric." American Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Boston, MA. September 2026. *Paper presentation (Scheduled)*.
9. "Civic Engagement and Gendered Leadership among NCAA Student-Athletes." American Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Boston, MA. September 2026. *Paper presentation (Scheduled)*.
8. "Christian Nationalism in Congressional Communication in the Twenty-First Century." Midwest Political Science Association Annual Conference, Chicago, IL. April 2026. *Paper presentation*.
7. "Presidential Religious Rhetoric and War." 2025 West Point Social Sciences Seminar, West Point, NY. February 2025. *Paper presentation*.
 - Coverage: https://press.westpoint.edu/wp-content/uploads/sites/5/2026/02/SOSH-2025-Layout_JMF4.pdf#page=53
6. "Leathernecks and Lexicon: Exploring Partisanship in the US Military." The Inter-University Seminar on Armed Forces and Society Canada Conference, Ottawa, Canada. October 2024. *Paper presentation (Virtual)*.
5. "Sacred Speech: Analyzing the Influence of Congressional Leadership on Religious Rhetoric." Society for the Scientific Study of Religion Annual Meeting, Pittsburgh, PA. October 2024. *Paper presentation*.
4. "From Silence to Speech: Women's Participation in Christian Nationalism." American Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA. September 2024. *Paper presentation*.
3. "Leathernecks and Lexicon: Exploring Partisanship in the US Military." American Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA. September 2024. *Paper presentation*.
2. "Leathernecks and Lexicon: Exploring Partisanship in the US Military." US Army War College Civil-Military Relations Center Annual Conference, Carlisle, PA. May 2024. *Paper presentation*.
1. "Faithful Leadership: Analyzing the Influence of Speaker Mike Johnson's Religious Identity in the House." Henry Institute Symposium on Religion and Public Life, Grand Rapids, MI. April 2024. *Paper presentation*.

Service and Leadership

To the Discipline

International Officer, Religion and Politics Specialist Group, Political Studies Association	2025-Present
Co-Organizer, Religion and Politics Working Group, MPSA Annual Meeting	2026
Panel Chair, West Point Social Sciences Seminar	2025
Panel Chair, Henry Symposium on Religion and Public Life	2024
Discussant, Henry Symposium on Religion and Public Life	2024
Reviewer: <i>Politics and Religion</i>	Ongoing

To the Institution

Leadership Team, Schar PhD Student Association, George Mason University	2025-Present
Consultant, Writing Support Lab, George Mason University	2024-Present
Alumni Admissions Interviewer, Dartmouth College	2020-Present
Treasurer, Schar PhD Student Association, George Mason University	2024-2025

To the Community

Division 1 Track and Field Coach, Villanova University	2024-2025
Division 1 Track and Field Coach, George Mason University	2023-2024

Professional Memberships

Canadian Political Science Association	2025-Present
Political Studies Association	2025-Present
Society for the Scientific Study of Religion	2024-Present
American Political Science Association	2023-Present

Skills

Computing: R, R Markdown, L^AT_EX, Qualtrics, Microsoft Suite